Frequently Asked questions on Potato farming

1. Question: What's the best type of soil for planting potatoes?

Response: Potatoes grow best in well-drained, deep, loamy, or sandy loam soil. It's important to have a soil pH between 5.5 and 6.0 for optimal growth.

2. Question: When should I apply fertilizer to my potatoes and what kind?

Response: Fertilizer application should be timed to coincide with critical growth stages. For early-maturing varieties, apply about two-thirds of the total nitrogen (N) needed pre-plant or at planting, with the rest applied in split applications after tuber formation. A good rule of thumb is to apply phosphorus-rich fertilizers during the early growth stage to stimulate rapid root development.

3. Question: What are the signs of late blight and how can I prevent it?

Response: Late blight is a fungal disease that can be devastating. Symptoms include water-soaked lesions on leaves and stems. To prevent it, you should use resistant varieties and certified disease-free seeds. In cool, wet weather, the disease can spread rapidly, so it's important to use fungicides as a preventative measure and in accordance with your crop's growth stage.

4. Question: What is the recommended spacing for planting potato seeds?

Response: Planting potatoes in ridges is a common method. The ridges should be about 75 cm apart, and the potato seeds should be spaced 30 cm apart within the ridge, at a depth of about 10 cm.

5. Question: Why do my potatoes have a green color and what should I do about it?

Response: The green color on potato tubers is caused by a compound called solanine. It develops when tubers are exposed to light. Solanine is toxic in high amounts. To prevent

this, ensure your potatoes are properly "hilled up" with soil to keep them covered throughout the growing season.

6. Question: How often should I be watering my potato crop?

Response: Potatoes have shallow roots and require regular watering. The most critical stages for irrigation are during stolen formation and tuber elongation. Drip irrigation is a good method because it applies water directly to the plant's roots, minimizing waste. If there is insufficient rainfall, watering is especially important when flowers appear and when tubers begin to form.

7. Question: What is the importance of crop rotation for potatoes?

Response: Crop rotation is a critical component of disease management. By rotating potatoes with non-host crops like maize or beans, you can break the life cycle of pests and diseases, such as potato cyst nematodes and bacterial wilt, that live in the soil.

8. Question: How do I know when my potatoes are ready for harvest?

Response: Potatoes are typically ready for harvest about 3 to 4 months after planting, depending on the variety. A key indicator is when the vines begin to die and dry out. You can also carefully dig up a test plant to check the size and maturity of the tubers before harvesting the entire field.

9. Question: What pests should I be most concerned about in potato farming and what are some control methods?

Response: Aphids are a common pest that can spread diseases like the potato leaf curl virus. Other pests include cutworms and leaf miners. To control them, you can use

insecticides or biological controls like ladybugs for aphids. Changing the location of your potato crop each year is also an important preventative measure.

10. Question: Can I use potatoes from the grocery store as seeds for my farm?

Response: No, it is not recommended to use potatoes from the grocery store as seed potatoes. Most potatoes sold in stores have been treated with a sprout inhibitor, which prevents them from growing. Additionally, they are not certified disease-free, so you risk introducing diseases into your soil that could persist for many years.